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ARLINGTON BOARD IS ALL-DEMOCRATIC

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By Evelyn Hsu

The new Arlington County Board, which will announce goals for the upcoming year at its traditional New Year's Day organization meeting tomorrow, will be an all-Democratic panel that includes the first black elected to county office since Reconstruction.

The board's 1988 agenda is expected to focus on low-cost housing and development, though development is not the divisive issue it is in neighboring Fairfax County. Members said they also plan to keep an eye on such issues as transportation, affirmative action, day care, and the general quality of life.

Arlington has a population of about 155,000 that includes large numbers of new immigrants. The county has the second lowest property tax rate in the metropolitan area and its services are generally highly regarded.

Its budget last year was \$319.2 million. Some board members said they expect this year to be a tight one fiscally as the county debates spending more on schools and housing while under pressure to reduce or maintain property tax rates.

Though the Democrats have held a majority of seats on the five-member board since 1983, the coming year will mark the first time in more than a decade that the Democrats have had complete control.

Democrats Albert C. Eisenberg and William T. Newman were sworn into office last week, having defeated two Republican-backed independents in an at-large race for two county board seats in November. This is Eisenberg's second term. Newman ran for the seat vacated by Michael E. Brunner, who had been the only Republican on the board.

To maintain the semblance of political balance, the Democrats have proposed maintaining about 20 percent of the seats on county advisory commissions for appointees designated by the Republican Party.

There is some dispute over which panels are included. James B. Robinson, a vice chairman of the Arlington Republican Party, said Eisenberg promised during the election campaign that Republicans would have a say on appointments to all boards, including the School Board. Eisenberg denies including the School Board. All five current members of the School Board were appointed by the Democrats.

Chairman John G. Milliken

John G. Milliken, the incoming board chairman, said in an interview that he will emphasize programs to enhance the county's "livability."

"The county is running well. We have the luxury of being able to focus on special projects," he said.

As chairman three years ago, Milliken pushed a project to beautify the Rosslyn-Ballston Metro corridor and said his focus in 1988 will be on similar projects that he will outline at tomorrow's meeting.

Milliken, 42, will be in the final year of his second term and was elected chairman by the board's Democratic majority for a one-year term. The chairman's pay, at \$13,533 a year, is slightly higher than the regular board members' annual salary of \$12,179.

But the real perk of the chairman's post is its added visibility, which could benefit Milliken in another run for a seat on the board or for some other office.

He unsuccessfully challenged Republican Rep. Frank R. Wolf in the 10th Congressional District last year. He is regarded as one of Northern Virginia's most prominent Democrats and is known for his low-key style, sense of humor and skills as a mediator.

Milliken grew up in Leesburg, attended Haverford College near Philadelphia and graduated from the University of Virginia law school.

He served as chief aide to Rep. Joseph L. Fisher, a Democrat who lost his seat to Wolf in 1980. Milliken is managing partner of Winston & Strawn, a law firm in the District. His wife Christine is executive director and general counsel for the National Association of Attorneys General. They live in the Arlington Ridge neighborhood in south Arlington.

Ellen M. Bozman

Ellen M. Bozman, who will be vice chairman of the board this year, acknowledges with a laugh that she has become a fixture in Arlington politics.

"I keep trying to think of a more sparkling word," she said. "I've learned so much that I can continue to be a new voice on the board."

In the third year of her fourth term as a county board member, Bozman, 62, has been an Arlington community activist for four decades.

Bozman is technically an independent but has run with Democratic backing and support from nonpartisan groups such as Arlingtonians for a Better County. She has been able to push legislation through even under Republican-dominated boards, a tribute, some say, to her shrewd political instincts.

Day care is an issue closely identified with Bozman. As chairman of the Health and Welfare Council, a predecessor of the United Way, Bozman helped put together a study in 1969 that led to the establishment of the extended day care program in Arlington schools.

Bozman said she will not focus on any one issue this year. "It's generally improving services for county residents," she said. "It ranges from child care to elderly care. We just need to keep making strides."

Bozman is a graduate of Northwestern University. She moved to Arlington in 1950, and is a past president of the Arlington and the metropolitan League of Women Voters. She and her husband, William H. Bozman, live in North Arlington and have three grown children.

Albert C. Eisenberg

By most accounts, Albert C. Eisenberg had a very good year.

Not only was he comfortably reelected, but as board chairman he helped engineer a deal in which part of the massive Lee Gardens apartment complex in the county was sold to a nonprofit group so some of the units could be set aside for low-income tenants. Extensive renovations by a private developer had displaced many of the 3,000 low-income residents, many of them Hispanics.

This year Eisenberg, 41, said he will seek to persuade his colleagues to create a county policy under which developers will be asked to help alleviate the county's low-cost housing crisis.

"It may involve contributions that are directly related to the {developer's} site or it may not. It could be anything. There are a dozen ways {to approach the problem}," he said. "Developers are not isolated from the housing crisis."

Eisenberg said he also will work on the historic preservation issues involving the Clarendon and Palisades areas, and neighborhood heritage programs involving artifacts and oral histories. He hopes to fashion guidelines by which neighborhoods could be considered for designation as historic districts.

Eisenberg is a lobbyist for the American Institute of Architects, and a former staff director of the Senate subcommittee on housing and urban affairs. He attended the University of Richmond and received a master's degree in education from Hampton Institute.

His wife, Sharon E. Davis, is a Democratic party activist and chief clerk of the House Energy and Commerce Committee. They have two young sons and live in Ashton Heights in central Arlington.

William T. Newman

William T. Newman is the board's only newcomer, but he comes with his niche in history secure. He is the first black elected to a county office since the 1870s.

"It's very significant, it's important, but in an ideal society you like to think if you are good and qualified you can do anything," he said, adding that many black community leaders before him were "eminently qualified" for office.

Newman, 37, said his efforts this year will focus on housing, affirmative action, the establishment of a human rights commission and combating the drug problem that has particularly affected parts of South Arlington.

While the board has for several years cut the property tax rate to offset some of the increase in assessments, Newman said, "I really wonder whether that will be even be possible this year." He cited the pressure to increase school and housing funding.

He also favors a study of police pay benefits because, he said, experienced officers are leaving the Arlington police force for jurisdictions with better benefits.

Early this year, the board will consider whether to allow a residence facility for women alcoholics and drug addicts and their children in a South Arlington neighborhood. Newman predicted a tough fight over the issue, but said, "There's a real need for it. The question again is where is the best place to put it."

Newman grew up in Arlington and attended local public schools. He graduated from Ohio University, received his law degree from Catholic University and has a law practice in Arlington. He spent a brief period as an actor and has one season on a soap opera to his credit.

He is single and lives in Arlington View in South Arlington. His mother Geraldine N. Newman, also lives in Arlington and sells real estate.

Mary Margaret Whipple

If the wording of legislation or a county document is even slightly amiss, Mary Margaret Whipple's colleagues are sure she will notice it.

Whipple, 47, is an eagle-eyed former English teacher and editor at the U.S. Office of Education. In the second year of her second term, she said transportation will be among her main concerns this year.

Whipple will also serve on the Metro board and the Northern Virginia Transportation Commission. "I'll be concentrating on transit in all its multi-rider forms, HOV lanes, car pools," she said.

One complaint she often hears is how confusing the Metro bus system is to riders. "I want to make the bus system, and I hate this word, more 'user friendly,' " she said.

Within Arlington, Whipple said she will work to update the county's transportation plan and study expansion of alternative transportation methods, particularly jitneys and buses serving small neighborhoods such as the experimental Crystal City trolley.

A native of Texas, Whipple has been a resident of Arlington since 1960. She attended American University and has a master's degree from George Washington University. She served a term on the School Board, from 1976 to 1980, and was elected to the County Board in 1982 where she has focused on issues including day care and language training for the foreign-born.

She and her husband, Thomas S. Whipple, a federal employee, live in North Arlington in a neighborhood north of the Washington Golf and Country Club. They have two children and a grandchild.

{All the County Board members can be reached at their offices in Room 201 of the Arlington County Court House, 1400 N. Court House Rd. The phone number is 558-2261.}